

ENGLISH **LIVE**

14

COMPREHENSION & VOCABULARY

UPSC / BANK PO / SSC / OTHERS

SESSION - 14

13th February, 2017



Letter and spirit

Transparency is the cornerstone of a robust democracy. The Government should lead by example in embracing the RTI Act

An analysis by this paper found that government agencies and institutions are increasingly finding ways to decline information sought under the Right to Information Act (RTI), 2005. The experience of citizens in using the RTI to access information has been largely less than satisfactory. Essentially, the Government and its agencies are finding ways to ensure that the RTI Act becomes an ineffective tool available to the citizens, thus defeating the very purpose for which it was enacted in the first place. It is unfortunate that a law that would have helped lower corruption in public offices and increase transparency in the functioning of government and thus help improve governance has become hostage to political and bureaucratic insecurity. Section 8(i) of the RTI Act together with its clauses have often been misused to deny information requests. This sweeping provision allows the government to deny any information that it perceives to be prejudicial to the sovereignty and integrity of the country, its security, strategic and economic interests or lead to incitement of an offence and would disproportionately divert resources of the public authority.

This is a pity. The RTI Act has helped expose large scams at the central and State level in the past. The Adarsh Housing Society scam, which led to resignation of the then Maharashtra chief minister Ashok Chavan, the Commonwealth Games scam and even the 2G scam were exposed as the result of RTI applications. But such exposes also had unintended consequences. Decision making in the Government came to a standstill particularly during the UPA government's second term. Scams exposed by RTI Act queries gave a handle to opposition parties to attack the ruling alliance and precipitate its downfall.

The RTI Act was revolutionary and designed to be more effective than the Freedom of Information Act enacted by the NDA government in 2002. The Act empowered citizens to hold public functionaries accountable for their actions. It held the promise of cleaning up governance, but that hope proved short-lived. Political parties ensured that they were not covered under the purview of the RTI Act through an amendment in 2013 and therefore were not answerable for their actions to ordinary citizens. Dedicated RTI activists have been verbally and physically abused, and some have even been killed. The government needs to accept that some discomfiture may be the inevitable outcome of any effective use of the Act, but the benefits – by way of changing how politicians, bureaucrats and lower level functionaries conduct themselves and the resultant improvement in governance standards – far outweigh the trouble. Any government that is committed to democratic values should improve transparency and be more accountable to the people it ostensibly exists to serve. It needs to take the lead in setting the right example by embracing the RTI Act in letter and spirit.



DISCUSSION ON 13th Feb (today)



DISCUSSION ON 14th Feb (tomorrow)

THE HINDU
BusinessLine

24th January 2017

BusinessLine

MONDAY, FEBRUARY 13, 2017

A bankable idea

A government-run ARC to mop up NPAs would require checks and balances

The crackdown on high-profile defaulter Vijay Malya may be making headlines, but there can be no escaping the urgent need to stem the rising tide of gross non-performing assets (at 9 per cent of bank lending or 4.5 per cent of the GDP, it amounts to ₹6.75 lakh crore and mounting). These have applied the breaks on lending by banks and investment by the indebted corporates concerned. Private investment had actually started to shrink by 2015-16 and in 2016-17 "so far it seems to have contracted by more than 7 per cent", the *Economic Survey 2017* notes. Clearly, the approach to NPAs cannot be business as usual. Acknowledging that the RBI and the Centre are running out of options, the Survey has mooted a none-too-novel idea of a 'bad bank', the Public Sector Asset Rehabilitation Agency (PARA), with 49 per cent government ownership. It appears that earlier efforts to clean up the mess and start on a clean slate – the SJS scheme, strategic debt restructuring and SAA (or Scheme for Sustainable Structuring of Stressed Assets) and private asset reconstruction companies – have not helped enough. PARA is expected to clean up the balance sheets of banks, leaving them free to lend without encumbrance, even as they are recapitalised to the extent of the write-downs. It appears that the Budget set aside only ₹10,000 crore for bank recapitalisation, against last year's ₹25,000 crore, with a view to arriving at greater clarity on the problem before committing the money. RBI deputy governor Viral Acharya has observed that a 'bad bank' will have to be "designed right" for it to work.

There are over 20 asset reconstruction companies (ARCs) in operation, many of them private players. Private ARCs, according to the Survey, have not picked up more than 4-5 per cent of the book value of the NPAs. This is because public sector banks, on the one hand, are not willing to write down losses to the extent that the ARCs would like, fearing vigilance repercussions, while on the other the ARCs cannot offer more when asset "resolution" is difficult. It remains to be seen how PARA will work where others haven't. A fine balance between institutional accountability and autonomy is called for. While PARA, as a government-owned entity, may be able to bring various creditors on board to agree on write-downs, it would also have to show urgency in recovering the monies. Even with the bankruptcy code coming into play, enabling the judiciary to put an end to protracted liquidation proceedings, PARA must be guided by an approach to revive industry wherever possible.

The RBI governor has rightly pointed to the need for "pragmatism" in dealing with the fraught issue of NPAs. This entails the recognition, as spelt out in the Survey, that NPAs are "an economic problem, not a morality play", the shenanigans over Malya notwithstanding. Ultimately, the objective should be to get credit growth back to double digit rates, with checks and balances to deal with irregularities.

LIVE

THE HINDU
BusinessLine

13th February 2017

**BusinessLine**

TUESDAY, JANUARY 24, 2017

Letter and spirit

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This is a pity. The RTI Act has helped expose large scams at the central and State level in the past. The Adarsh Housing Society scam, which led to resignation of the then Maharashtra chief minister Ashok Chavan, the Commonwealth Games scam and even the 2G scam were exposed as the result of RTI applications. But such exposes also had unintended consequences. Decision making in the Government came to a standstill particularly during the UPA government's second term. Scams exposed by RTI Act queries gave a handle to opposition parties to attack the ruling alliance and precipitate its downfall.

The RTI Act was revolutionary and designed to be more effective than the Freedom of Information Act enacted by the NDA government in 2002. The Act empowered citizens to hold public functionaries accountable for their actions. It held the promise of cleaning up governance, but that hope proved short-lived. Political parties ensured that they were not covered under the purview of the RTI Act through an amendment in 2013 and therefore were not answerable for their actions to ordinary citizens. Dedicated RTI activists have been verbally and physically abused, and some have even been killed. The government needs to accept that some discomfiture may be the inevitable outcome of any effective use of the Act, but the benefits — by way of changing how politicians, bureaucrats and lower level functionaries conduct themselves and the resultant improvement in governance standards — far outweigh the trouble. Any government that is committed to democratic values should improve transparency and be more accountable to the people it ostensibly exists to serve. It needs to take the lead in setting the right example by embracing the RTI Act in letter and spirit.

Letter and spirit

THE HINDU
BusinessLine**24th January 2017**

Letter and spirit

LIVE

Transparency is the **cornerstone** of a **robust democracy**. The Government should lead by example in **embracing** the RTI Act

- An analysis by this paper found that government agencies and institutions are increasingly finding ways to decline information sought under the Right to Information Act (RTI), 2005. The experience of citizens in using the RTI to access information has been largely less than satisfactory.
- Essentially, the Government and its agencies are finding ways to ensure that the RTI Act becomes an ineffective tool available to the citizens, thus defeating the very purpose for which it was **enacted** in the first place. It is unfortunate that a law that would have helped lower corruption in public offices and increase **transparency** in the functioning of government and thus help improve governance has become **hostage** to political and **bureaucratic** insecurity.
- Section 8(1) of the RTI Act together with its clauses have often been misused to **deny** information requests.
- This **sweeping** provision allows the government to deny any information that it perceives to be **prejudicial** to the **sovereignty** and **integrity** of the country, its security, **strategic** and economic interests or lead to **incitement** of an **offence** and would disproportionately divert resources of the public authority.
- This is a pity. The RTI Act has helped **expose** large **scams** at the central and State level in the past. The Adarsh Housing Society scam, which led to resignation of the then Maharashtra chief minister Ashok Chavan, the Commonwealth Games scam and even the 2G scam were exposed as the result of RTI applications.
- But such exposes also had **unintended** consequences. Decision making in the Government came to a **standstill** particularly during the UPA government's second term. Scams exposed by RTI Act queries gave a handle to opposition parties to attack the ruling alliance and **precipitate** its downfall.
- The RTI Act was revolutionary and designed to be more effective than the Freedom of Information Act enacted by the NDA government in 2002. The Act **empowered** citizens to hold public functionaries accountable for their actions. It held the promise of cleaning up governance, but that hope proved **short-lived**. Political parties ensured that they were not covered under the purview of the RTI Act through an amendment in 2013 and therefore were not answerable for their actions to ordinary citizens.
- Dedicated RTI activists have been verbally and physically abused, and some have even been killed. The government needs to accept that some **discomfiture** may be the **inevitable** outcome of any effective use of the Act, but the benefits — by way of changing how politicians, bureaucrats and lower level functionaries conduct themselves and the resultant improvement in governance standards — far **outweigh** the trouble. Any government that is committed to democratic values should improve transparency and be more accountable to the people it **ostensibly** exists to serve. It needs to take the lead in setting the right example by embracing the RTI Act in letter and spirit.



Letter and spirit

Letter and spirit

Transparency is the *cornerstone* of a *robust democracy*. The Government should lead by example in *embracing* the RTI Act

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Letter and Spirit



Letter and Spirit

Obeying literal interpretation and obeying the intent of those who framed



Opaque



Opaque

Prevent light from travelling through

Transparent



Transparent

Can see through it very clearly



Cornerstone



Family is the
cornerstone of
Indian society.



Cornerstone

Stone at corner with date in a building

Cornerstone

Something of great importance that everything else depends on



Robust

*Indian
economy is
robust*



*SBI is quite
robust
organization*

Robust

Strong / healthy / unlikely to fail



Democracy



USA is one of the oldest
democratic countries.

Democracy

Freedom and equality and power by the elected
representatives, elected directly by the people



Embrace

The refugees from Syria must be **embraced** by the advanced countries.



Embrace

To accept something enthusiastically



Letter and spirit

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Enact

Parliament **enacted** a law to create Real Estate Regulatory Authorities in States.



Enact

To make a law or a rule become official



Hostage

The Minister was taken
hostage by the gunmen.



Hostage

Someone is taken as a prisoner by an enemy in order to force / get something



Bureaucracy



Collector (IAS)



Clerks



SP (IPS)



Police

Bureaucracy

System for controlling or managing a country, company and operated by large number of officials



Letter and spirit

Section 8(1) of the RTI Act together with its clauses have often been misused to *deny* information requests.



Deny

Govt. **denied** the
allegations of excessive
Govt. interference in the
working of RBI.



Deny

To say that something is not true



Letter and spirit

This *sweeping* provision allows the government to deny any information that it perceives to be *prejudicial* to the *sovereignty* and *integrity* of the country, its security, *strategic* and economic interests or lead to *incitement* of an *offence* and would disproportionately divert resources of the public authority.



Sweeping

Sweeping reforms are required in the legal system.



Sweeping

Making a big difference to a particular situation and effecting substantial number of people



Prejudice

Laws against caste
prejudice must be strictly
enforced.



Prejudice

Forming unreasonable / unfair opinion, without enough thought or knowledge



Sovereignty

India is a **sovereign**
country.



Sovereignty

The power of a country to control its own Government



Integrity

He is a man of
unimpeachable
integrity and
character.



Honesty and strong moral
principles

Integrity

Unity and **integrity**
of the country is
of paramount
importance.



सत्यमेव जयते

Integrity

Institution that remains undivided



Strategic

Turkey is in **strategic** location; peace in Turkey is important to ensure peace in West Asia.



Strategic

Obtaining the details of account holders in foreign banks is the **strategic** objective to control black money.



सत्यमेव जयते

Strategic

Relates to the way a country / company decides, what it wants to achieve



Incitement

They denied **inciting** the crowd to violence.



Incitement

To encourage someone to do or feel something unpleasant or violent



Offence

Driving a car without a
licence is an **offence**.



Offence

Illegal act, Crime



Letter and spirit

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Expose

My tenure with
Goldman Sachs
gave **exposure** to
complex financial
issues.

Goldman
Sachs



The **Audit exposed** corruption
in revenue department.

Expose

Create conditions to allow someone
the opportunity to learn

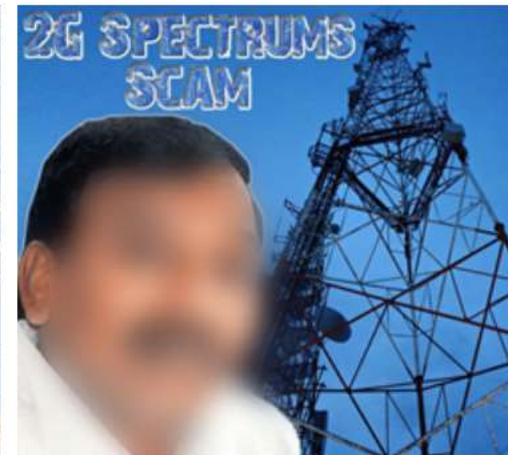
Expose

To make public
something bad or dishonest



Scam

The stature of India has gone down because of coal **scam** / 2 G **scam**.



Scam

Illegal plan for making money



Letter and spirit

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Intended / Unintended

The **intended** benefits of demonetization are not many, but it has several **unintended** consequences.



Intended

To have a purpose



Standstill

The traffic on NH1 came
to a **standstill**.



Standstill

A situation when all the movement or activity has stopped



Precipitate

The highhandedness of police on Uighur activists will **precipitate** the crisis.



Precipitate

To make something happen suddenly or sooner than expected



Letter and spirit

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Empower

Bank loans to
Self Help
Groups in our
country
resulted in
empowerment
of women



Self Help Groups



73rd & 74th
Amendments to
the Constitution
empowered
Panchayati Raj
Institutions in
our country

Empower

The process of giving people / organization more freedom / rights
/ official authority / legal power



Short-lived

*Their marital relationship became **short-lived**, because of persistent differences.*



Short-lived

Lasts only for a short time



Letter and spirit

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Inevitable

The accident was the
inevitable consequence
of carelessness.



Inevitable

Certain to happen / one cannot prevent



Outweigh

The benefits of this
cancer treatment far
outweigh any risks.



Outweigh

More important than something else



Ostensibly

Her **ostensible** cheerfulness concedes sadness, as she lost her husband recently.



Ostensibly

Appears to be one thing, but it is really something else



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